STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 05 · Pick Up the Weight

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey, men. Good to see you in the room. Last lesson, you named a thing you'd been putting off. Some of you moved. Some of you— some of you moved it onto a cleaner list. I know that list. Uh, I invented a few. Real quick. There's a sheet in the back for who brings what. I looked at the chili. I looked at the brisket. I wrote my name by the napkins. Yeah. I've been picking the light thing for years and calling it service. I'm Wes. You already know. I'll skip the long hello. Here's where this lesson is headed. Stay with me. One sentence gives us four marks for a real man. I mean, I'm not improving on them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

The last lesson was that first mark. You got on your feet. Uh, I'm glad you did. Standing there is not the same as carrying.

This lesson stays on the second mark. Picks up the weight.

Here's the whole thing, plain. The weight that has your name on it does not move until you put a hand on it.

You can talk about it. You can explain it. You can wait until it feels fair. And, you know, it still sits there. A hand has to land on it.

So the name for this lesson is simple. You pick up the weight. One weight. Your name on it. Your hand. We'll get to a sentence you can finish. We'll sort what is yours, uh, from what was never yours. I want the man who's winning at work in the same room as the man who feels behind. Same mark. Uh, same sentence. You don't get to watch your own life from the curb. Some of you walked in tired. You still made it in. Good. This is for you too. If your name is on it, it's yours to pick up.

Blame is an old move. A man sets his weight down and points at whoever is standing closest. It makes the afternoon easier. Uh, I know the move. I made it over a school form on the counter. One of my kids needed it signed. The school needed it that day. I had— I had a clean explanation. The note went to my wife, the site was a mess, uh, somebody should've told me twice, I had the whole list ready. All of it was true enough to say at a normal volume. Uh, Friday came. The form was still blank. My kid was the one standing there without it.

She was not the problem. I was fine letting her be the one who noticed.

You can be right about the cause and still be the man who left it sitting. Right? A storm you didn't order can still drop branches in your yard. You didn't vote for the branches. They're in the grass, uh, in the morning anyway. A boss can change a schedule in an office you'll never see. Your boy can still need a ride on Saturday. Nobody in that office is coming down your street.

Fault asks who started it. Responsibility asks a smaller question. Whose hands is it in now?

Fairness is how a boy thinks when the whistle blows and he wants the call. A man can love a fair call and still bend down and pick up what's in front of him.

Uh, hear me on this. I am not saying you caused every heavy thing in your life. Some of you are standing under weather you did not make. This is not me handing you somebody else's share. How many of you walked in today already explaining a weight you've been holding in your mouth instead of in your hands? Go on. I'm not taking names. Yeah. That's most of us. Uh, me included. If your only sentence starts with yeah but, the weight is still in the air. It has not landed on you. And until it lands, you can't carry it. You can only describe it.

So here's the sentence. You're gonna need it at the table, so learn it in the room. That is mine.

Three words. Then a period. Then you stop.

The minute you add but, you've started a second speech, and the person in front of you hears the weight slide. I practiced a short apology in the truck. Uh, no defense in it. I liked it. Uh, I texted, on my way, from the driveway. Which is, uh, technically true. By the back door, I'd added— I'd added a paragraph about my day. She heard the paragraph. The first sentence didn't survive it.

I mean, she didn't need my afternoon. She needed the period. A but is how the weight jumps to the nearest person. A because does the same job in a nicer shirt. Context can be true and, you know, still be a slide out of the sentence. Own how it landed, not how hard you meant to. Effort is a story you tell about yourself. The result is what the other person lived.

If you said you'd call, the call is the result. The busy afternoon is just the story. Your people are not required to frame your intentions. Look, I'm not against an explanation later. Later is fine. Later is not the first sentence. First sentence. That is mine. Period.

If you're married, she has heard the but. She can hear a period too, if you actually finish. Uh, if you're young, you don't need a long speech to be grown in this. You need one finished line. Uh, hear how fast the but tries to sneak in. Say it in your head. The way you'd say it to a man you respect. Short. No rescue clause at the end. That is mine. Then close your mouth and let the quiet do the rest.

Five things have your name on them. Uh, not everything in the world. These five. Your season changes the shape of the work. It does not take your name off it.

First one. Your life.

There's a bag by our front door. It's been there so long the dog thinks it's furniture. I step over it. And I call that a plan. Nobody is coming to live your life for you. Your word, when nobody's writing it down. The habit you break by lunch after you swore it off at night. What you do with your body when the house is quiet. Whether you talk to God, uh, or you only talk about talking to God. Uh, that bag is yours. Step over it long enough and you've made a decision. If you're young, hear this. Before you carry a girl, or a title, or a bunch of younger guys who look up to you, carry yourself.

If you're single, the life is already yours. You don't get a pass until somebody else moves in. If you live — if you live alone, nobody's grading the evening. You can go dark inside your own walls and the lights still come on.

Uh, second weight. Your house, if you share one. The state of that marriage, from your side, is not a mystery you're waiting out. I mean, she needs you in the room. Not just on the account. I can fund a month and still be a guest at my own table, uh, keys in my hand, while they eat. Six thirty does not care what the scoreboard at work said at four.

Kids don't collect speeches. They collect what you do when you're tired, whether you look up, whether a man is actually at the table. If the marriage already came apart, I'm not relitigating papers in this room. Your kids still need a father who stays put on his days.

That share is still in your hands.

Third. The work in front of you today. Uh, do it straight. Not for show. The man who needs it from you, you know, doesn't need a forecast. He needs a day he can count on. Don't hand him a forecast. Cloudy. Out of your hands. Uh, a forecast sounds kinder than a date. Say the date anyway. Finish it all the way. Half-done is a story. Done is what the other man can use.

Uh, fourth. The people tied to you. Not every name on a screen. Uh, the man two chairs over you keep meaning to check on. The nephew who only gets you on the big days. You can't rescue him. You also don't get to pretend you didn't see him.

How many of you are the first call when something breaks for somebody else, and the last man to sit down at your own table? You can be honest. This room can hold it. Yeah. I have been that man. Fifth, and this is the one we drop first. What you— what you did wrong.

Not what was done to you. The sharp answer you gave a kid who didn't have it coming. The promise about Saturday you let die quiet. The thing you still haven't said to the person who was in the room. Leave it unsaid and it doesn't stay where you hid it. It leaks. The people near you end up wearing a mood you wouldn't name.

Some of you were handed things that were never yours to carry. What was done to you matters. I'm not brushing past it. Go slow. This page is the one that still has your name, the part you can actually pick up.

An older man I sat with, Leon, held his phone most of one evening. His son was grown. They hadn't talked straight in a long while. Leon didn't build a speech. Uh, he called. The son didn't answer. Leon set the phone down. He said, I'll try again. If you want back in, ask. Start that small. One true sentence. Then wait it out. No closing argument.

Let me tell you about a man I sat with a long time. I'll call him, uh, Wade. Wade was the first yes in the group text. You needed a trailer, he was already backing up. A man was in a waiting room, Wade brought supper. Something broke on a job, he was in the truck. Guys said, that is a responsible man. They weren't wrong about the part they could see. His girl asked him to dinner. Uh, not a crisis. A Thursday. Her place. She was cooking for him, first time, and she texted a picture of the table as if it was a holiday. He said yes that morning. Uh, he meant it. That afternoon a buddy's truck died on the side of a road, maybe ten minutes from Wade's place. Dead battery. Wade looked at the clock. He told himself, this is what men do. He texted her, start without me. He went to the truck. He told me— he told me it fired on one tap. One tap.

She had already eaten. With her roommate. No scene. Just a finished plate and a dad who didn't make it.

Wade wasn't a cruel man. He was a useful man. Useful to whoever was loudest. Helping a buddy is good. Uh, hear that. Wade wasn't wrong to care. He was wrong about which weight had his name that hour. The buddy had other men he could call. His girl had one dad.

He thought she might not ask again. I would've, uh, thought the same. She did ask. Uh, smaller. A shelf she couldn't hold and reach at the same time. He said, I'm coming. He silenced the phone. Uh, he went. They ate what she had left over. He washed the plate. He didn't give a speech about being a father. He was just there. The truck could wait.

That's the turn I don't want you to miss. The loud thing was easy, and he called it duty. The quiet thing had his name on it, and he set it down.

Now listen. Wade's story can get heard wrong. A man can, uh, walk out of it thinking he should never help anybody. That's not what I said. Paul writes two lines, close together, and at first they seem to argue. Galatians six, verse two. Carry each other's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ. Uh, a few lines down. Verse five. For each one should carry their own load.

It's not— it's not a contradiction. In the language he wrote in, those are two different words. A load is the share with your name on it. Sized for you. You put it on. You don't make a speech about it. A burden is the crushing kind. One back wasn't made for it. Picture it this way. Your spare tire, you change that yourself, on the shoulder, Uh, no audience. Right? A transmission on the garage floor, you call a man. You don't call that quitting. You call that sense. So get your own load on first. Then get under a brother when the thing on him is crushing him. You don't wait for a polished invite when a man is actually down. And you don't skip the thing with your name on it so you can be seen helping somewhere else. The people in your house, uh, can tell. If the order is backwards, you can be everybody's answer and a ghost where your name is.

When the crushing part is yours, ask. Ask God. Ask two or three men to get under the piece that's flattening you. Uh, you're still the one who owns your load. Handing off the part that would break you is not the same as setting it down.

Name the weight out loud. Hand the crushing piece to men who can hold it with you. Uh, don't perform the struggle alone and call that strength. It may be the most responsible hour you spend.

Pride will strap a weight on you that God never put in your hands, because an empty hand can shame a man. Uh, I know that pull. You've felt that pull. Whether the men at the job think well of you. A buddy's sobriety, as if you could want it into him. The way your sister runs her house when she didn't ask you to run it. The mood of a whole holiday, uh, as if you were in charge of everyone's peace. That's not— that's not devotion. That's a man who doesn't trust God with the people he loves.

You can care. You can pray. You can show up. You are not in charge of another adult's peace.

Leave their soul where it belongs. Love them, uh, with your feet, not with a harness. Some of you set your own stuff down and call it being lowly. Some of you pick up everybody's stuff and call it being strong. Both of those are a way around the sentence.

The sentence is still, that is mine, about the one thing that is. I mean, clarity is the mark. Uh, guilt is not. If you leave here and pick up three new weights just so you feel you did something, you missed me. One. The one with your name.

And if you're the man who got crushed by what somebody else chose, don't you pick their sin up and call it your assignment. Grieve it. Tell God the truth about it. Tell a brother, when you can. Then come back to the load that is still yours to carry today.

I'm talking to the strong man and the tired man in the same breath. Uh, both of you want a loophole. There isn't one that takes your name off your own stuff. Your habits. Your word. The people actually tied to you. The wrong that has your fingerprints, not somebody else's.

One more thing, and it's where a lot of good men slip. We think providing is, uh, a transfer. Uh, money moves. We did our part. I kept a house running on time. Trash day never slipped. The truck, uh, got its oil. Nobody was late on the calendar. I had the records to prove I was doing fine. My wife said, one night, she was— she was lonely in a house that ran on time.

I almost handed her a maintenance report. She was talking about lonely.

The report would've been accurate. It would've also been a way to disappear while looking responsible. Write this where you can see it when you get to the page. Provision that costs your presence is not provision. It is a very expensive way to disappear.

Presence is not a prize you buy after the bills are, you know, perfect. Presence is part of what you owe the people under your roof, and the people who still look for you even if the roof changed. So give something money can't. Put the phone face down and leave it there until they're done talking. Take the walk around the block with your kid. Uh, no headphones. Be at the ordinary meal, and stay through the cleanup. If you live alone, take back one thing you've been handing off. The call you've been letting your mom make. The hard talk with the landlord you keep forwarding. Uh, the plan you let a roommate carry so you don't have to decide. Carry it yourself. Today. A scoreboard can be honest and still be the wrong room. Your people don't eat a scoreboard. If your people are little, get down where they are for a few minutes. Uh, their game does not care about your day. If your people are grown, send the plain text. Don't decorate it. They eat a man who stayed.

How do you pick it up? Uh, not in theory. In a real room, with a real person. Look at the one it concerns. Say it— say it to their face if you can. That is mine.

Not the polished version. Not, I hear you, and here's the history. History can be true. History can also be the but, wearing a tie. Say the three words. Then stop. If you hear a but coming, you already left. Start over. That is mine. Period.

Uh, own the result. Not the speech about the result. Then do one thing with your hands that matches the sentence. A sentence with no feet is just a mood. If the person isn't standing there, call. Or write it and send it the same day. Uh, don't store the sentence in a note and call that done. If you live alone, say it about your own life, to God, and then to one man who will ask you. And if it's too heavy, you already know the other half. You ask. You don't pretend. There's a Man who did this in a way none of us can copy clean. I mean, I don't want to rush past Him. Jesus carried a cross He did not owe. In the

garden He asked if another way was open. Then He got up and went. He told the Father the truth about the weight. He did not hand it back. Nobody honest could look at Him and say, that wreck was yours to cause. Uh, he didn't point. He didn't add a but. He took it.

You and I are not the rescue. We don't save a house by acting large. He already carried what we could not carry. That's why a forgiven man can face his own load without using the load as a way to pay God back. Forgiveness is settled. Uh, the load is what's left for a son to pick up.

So don't point. Don't perform. Put your hand on the one weight that has your name, and leave it there.

So let me say it plain, one more time. The big idea is not complicated. The weight with your name on it does not move until your hand is on it.

Uh, fault is a real question. It is not the last question. Say that is mine, and stop at the period. Carry your own load. Get under a brother's crushing weight when it's actually crushing. Ask when the piece would break you. And be, uh, in the room. Money without you is a costly way to vanish.

What I hope you walk out of this lesson with is not a feeling about being a better man. Feelings fade, uh, in the truck. I hope you walk out with one true sentence, a period on the end, and your hand still on the thing you named.

When you get to your tables, open the workbook to this part. Three questions. Uh, stay on them. Can you say that is mine about one weight, without a but after it?

Where have you been providing everything for the house except yourself? If you live alone, ask it this way. Where have you been letting somebody else carry you? And what is one provision that isn't money, one you'll keep doing from this lesson on? The page calls it a non-money provision. One. Not ten. Write the line. That is mine. Period. Say it out loud, uh, at the table. If a silent but is still hanging on the end, cross the but out before you get up. Say the five once, so they stick. My life. My house. My work. My people. What I did wrong. Tell a brother the sentence and what you did with it. Ask him to check on you. Give him something real to ask about. If you're working this, uh, alone, still tell one man. Same day. Here's the thing. One line— one line, and then a period. Provision that costs your presence is not provision. It is a very expensive way to disappear.

Put a hand on what's yours.

Go to your tables. Work that part of the workbook together.